

MASTERING QUESTION 1

Cambridge O Level English Language 1123 • Paper 1 Reading

All question types • Exact past-paper wording • Complete official extracts

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this worksheet, you should be able to identify every major Q1 question type, decide whether it tests R1 or R2, follow the exact command words, and construct a mark-focused answer.

What does Question 1 test?

Objective	Official meaning	Student-friendly meaning
R1	demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings	The answer is stated: locate it, select it and reword it only when instructed.
R2	demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes	The answer is suggested: infer it from precise textual clues.

THE GOLDEN DIFFERENCE

R1 = FIND IT. R2 = INFER IT AND PROVE IT.

Command-word map

- **identify / what:** give the exact relevant information.
- **give two details / features / reasons:** select two separate points.
- **using your own words, explain:** replace every tested meaning.
- **explain why:** give the cause, not merely the event.
- **what is X thinking?:** infer the unstated thought.
- **how does X feel? Give details:** name the feeling, then support it.
- **different feelings ... Give three details:** give different feeling–evidence pairs.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Do not memorise question numbers. Cambridge can move a skill to a different part. Recognise the command words.

PART A — R1: Find and Reword

1. Identify one detail

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“I stop because I’m tired, hungry and have no idea where I am. The only sign of civilisation is a railway track which rests on a raised bed of gravel and rattles faintly in the darkness. A warning whistle shrieks and a massive engine explodes around the bend, thumping along the track. It is huge and churns out rolling clouds of billowing smoke, passing so close I’m hit by a wall of wind. The sudden sight, sound and stink are too much.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Text A: The circus train, paragraph 1, lines 1–5

From paragraph 1, identify one sound that suggests that a train is coming before the engine comes into sight.

[1]
R1

HOW TO ANSWER

Circle “paragraph 1”, “identify one” and “sound”. Select one sound only; no explanation is required.

MODEL ANSWER

The railway track “rattles faintly”.

Marks: one precise sound = 1

COMMON TRAP

“A massive engine explodes around the bend” describes its appearance and movement; the safest answers are the rattle or whistle.

SIR RUFUS TIP

IDENTIFY means locate and write. One mark, one precise response, then stop.

2. Explain a phrase in your own words

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“I snap out of my stupor. There are people on that train. Wherever it’s going, it’s travelling towards civilisation and food. I start running in the same direction as the train, scanning desperately for something to grab on to. Spotting an open door, I lunge forwards, reaching for the iron grab-bar and flinging myself upwards.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 2, lines 7–10

Using your own words, explain what the text means by “scanning desperately”.

[2]
R1

HOW TO ANSWER

SPLIT → REPLACE → REBUILD. “Scanning” = searching/looking carefully. “Desperately” = urgently/anxiously or with great need.

MODEL ANSWER

He is searching urgently and anxiously for something he can hold.

Marks: meaning of scanning = 1; meaning of desperately = 1

COMMON TRAP

“Looking desperately” changes only one tested word. Both meaning units must be explained.

SIR RUFUS TIP

A two-mark own-words phrase usually contains two separate meanings. Reword both.

3. Identify what was said**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“‘You like circuses?’ I must look puzzled because Camel lets loose with a toothless cackle. ‘Kid, don’t tell me you didn’t notice.’ ‘Notice what?’ I ask. ‘Ah, that’s hilarious,’ he says, wiping his eyes with the back of his hand. ‘You landed on a circus train, boy.’ I blink at him. ‘That there’s the circus tent – the big top,’ he says, waving the lamp at great faded rolls of canvas. ‘And this man here is Uncle Al.’”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 3, lines 26–33

In paragraph 3, Jacob is asked a question that confuses him. What is the question?

**[1]
R1**

MODEL ANSWER

“You like circuses?”

Marks: correct question = 1

SIR RUFUS TIP

Answer the exact task. “What is the question?” does not mean “Why is he confused?”

PART B — R2: Explain and Infer**4. Explain why****READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“‘You like circuses?’ I must look puzzled because Camel lets loose with a toothless cackle. ‘Kid, don’t tell me you didn’t notice.’ ‘Notice what?’ I ask. ‘Ah, that’s hilarious,’ he says, wiping his eyes with the back of his hand. ‘You landed on a circus train, boy.’ I blink at him. ‘That there’s the circus tent – the big top,’ he says, waving the lamp at great faded rolls of canvas.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 3, lines 26–33

Why is Jacob confused by the question?

**[1]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

Use the surrounding lines. Identify what Jacob has not understood and explain why the circus question seems unexpected.

MODEL ANSWER

He has not realised that he is travelling on a circus train, so the question seems unexpected.

Marks: valid reason = 1

COMMON TRAP

“He is confused because he is asked a question” repeats the event but gives no reason.

SIR RUFUS TIP

WHY asks for the cause. Do not merely retell what happened.

5. Explain a comparison in context**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“‘So, just looking for adventure, Mr College Boy?’ He’s smirking, clearly amused. ‘No, sir, I ...’ ‘Is he right?’ interrupts Camel. ‘Are you a college boy?’ I feel like a mouse being bounced between two cats. ‘I was.’ ‘Study something useful?’ Uncle Al’s eyes gleam in mockery.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 4, lines 36–42

Explain why Jacob says “I feel like a mouse being bounced between two cats.”

**[1]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

In Q1, translate the image into Jacob’s real situation: mouse = small/powerless; cats = threatening, controlling men.

MODEL ANSWER

Jacob feels powerless, vulnerable and threatened because the two men control the situation.

Marks: valid contextual meaning = 1

COMMON TRAP

“It is a simile” names a technique but does not explain Jacob’s situation.

SIR RUFUS TIP

In Q1, explain what an image means. In Q2, explain how the image creates an effect.

6. Impression plus two supporting details**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“There’s no mistaking Uncle Al as he steps forwards theatrically into the pool of lantern light. He has showman written all over him, from his ridiculously curled moustache and huge belly to his booming

voice: ‘So, just looking for adventure, Mr College Boy?’ He’s smirking, clearly amused. ‘No, sir, I ...’ ‘Is he right?’ interrupts Camel. ‘Are you a college boy?’ I feel like a mouse being bounced between two cats. ‘I was.’ ‘Study something useful?’ Uncle Al’s eyes gleam in mockery.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 4, lines 34–42

In paragraph 4, what is Uncle Al’s impression of Jacob before he finds out that Jacob studied veterinary sciences? Give two details from the text to support your answer.

**[3]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

Use the 1 + 2 structure: IMPRESSION + DETAIL 1 + DETAIL 2. The details must come from separate pieces of evidence and must support the same impression.

MODEL ANSWER

Uncle Al looks down on Jacob and considers his education useless or irrelevant. He calls him “Mr College Boy” and asks sarcastically whether he studied “something useful”.

Marks: impression = 1; two supporting details = 2

COMMON TRAP

Do not write only “He does not like Jacob”. State the nature of the impression—scornful, judgemental or unimpressed—and prove it.

SIR RUFUS TIP

An impression is a judgement. State it clearly, then select two details that reveal that judgement.

7. Infer unspoken thoughts

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“‘I studied veterinary sciences.’ His expression changes instantly: ‘Vet school? You’re a vet?’ ‘Not exactly. I never wrote my final exams.’ ‘Why not?’ ‘I just didn’t.’ ‘And those final exams, those were in your final year?’ ‘Yes.’ Camel and Uncle Al exchange glances.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 4, lines 43–50

Explain what Camel and Uncle Al are thinking when they “exchange glances”.

**[2]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

Ask what new information both men now share and why it matters to the sick animal.

MODEL ANSWER

They realise that Jacob has useful veterinary knowledge and may be able to treat the sick giraffe.

Marks: useful knowledge = 1; may help/treat giraffe = 1

COMMON TRAP

“They look at each other” repeats the action; it does not infer their thoughts.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Actions and dialogue are clues. Infer the thought that logically produces the action.

PART C — R1 and R2: Select Evidence Precisely

8. Give two physical signs

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“I’m escorted to the giraffe’s carriage. There’s pus flowing down the giraffe’s long nasal passage. She seems sad imprisoned here. She’s the most elegant creature I’ve ever seen. Her legs and neck are delicate; her body is sloped and covered with markings like puzzle pieces to the top of her triangular head. Her eyes are huge, dark and beautiful, and she has velvet-soft lips. She’s wearing a rope around her neck which I hold, but she’s too weak to move as I swab out her infected nostrils and swaddle her throat in a soft cloth.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, paragraph 5, lines 51–56

From paragraph 5, give two physical signs that indicate that the giraffe is ill.

[2]
R1

HOW TO ANSWER

Select two visible bodily or movement signs. Keep them separate.

MODEL ANSWER

- Pus is flowing from her nostrils.
- She is too weak to move.

Marks: one mark for each separate sign

COMMON TRAP

“She seems sad” is an emotional impression, not a physical sign.

SIR RUFUS TIP

A physical sign must be visible in the body or movement.

9. Feeling plus two supporting details

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“Trees near the entrance to the visitor centre became Odin’s favourite spot. He loved hiding there, undetected, before jumping out to land on people’s shoulders and peck affectionately at their ears.

This is fine for anyone used to birds, but disconcerting for those who aren't – especially children, who squealed loudest. Odin rarely missed an opportunity including when one afternoon, attracted to the children's play area by shouts of alarm, I found him dancing round, beak open, eyes gleaming, revelling in the mayhem he was causing."

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Text A: *The Raven*, paragraph 6, lines 25–30

In paragraph 6, how do children visiting the centre feel about Odin? Give two details from the text to support your answer.

**[3]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

Use the 1 + 2 structure: FEELING (own words) + DETAIL 1 + DETAIL 2. Match both details to the stated feeling.

MODEL ANSWER

The children feel frightened and alarmed. They "squealed", and their reactions are described as "shouts of alarm".

Marks: feeling = 1; two relevant details = 2

COMMON TRAP

Quotations alone are evidence, not the inferred feeling. "Bad" or "negative" is too vague.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Name the emotion first. Then prove that exact emotion with two short details.

Weak → partial → full marks

Answer	Likely marks	Why
They "squealed" and there were "shouts of alarm".	2/3	Two details; feeling missing.
They feel frightened because they "squealed".	2/3	Feeling + one detail.
They feel frightened. They "squealed" and there were "shouts of alarm".	3/3	Feeling + two details.

PART D — R1: Reasons and Consequences

10. Give two reasons

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“As well as pecking people, Odin had mastered the irritating art of imitating my voice. On several occasions, he’d escaped from his cage and convinced my busy wife, Julie, that I was calling her from the farm. When she arrived at the empty spot, Odin would be there enjoying her confusion.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 7, lines 31–34

From paragraph 7, give two reasons why Julie is annoyed with Odin.

[2]
R1

HOW TO ANSWER

Select two distinct reasons. Do not split one idea into repeated wording.

MODEL ANSWER

- Odin imitates Rex’s voice and tricks Julie.
- He wastes her time when she is busy.

Marks: one mark for each distinct reason

COMMON TRAP

“He annoys her” repeats the question. Explain what he does and why it causes annoyance.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Two reasons must be genuinely separate. Do not disguise repetition as a second point.

11. Identify two relevant features

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“My plan, as always, was to get the bird back into the wild, but this one would be tricky. Birds not only have to learn to find their own food, they also must learn to spot predators – difficult when a bird’s been in captivity from an early age with no parents to teach by example. It’s important when rearing wild birds that they’re kept as wild as possible, not treated like pets, so they have a chance of survival once released. This raven was called Odin and had no fear of people.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 3, lines 11–15

From paragraph 3, give two features of the bird’s upbringing that will make it difficult to return this bird to the wild.

[2]
R1

HOW TO ANSWER

The focus is UPBRINGING, not general behaviour. Select two different disadvantages caused by captivity.

MODEL ANSWER

- He has not learned to find his own food.
- He had no parents to teach him how to recognise predators.

Marks: one mark for each feature

COMMON TRAP

“He is mischievous” comes from another paragraph and does not explain difficulty surviving in the wild.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Underline the focus word. A correct detail from the wrong focus cannot earn the mark.

PART E — R2: Different Feelings Across the Text

12. Track changing feelings

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

Paragraph 1: “The young bird seemed too big for the box in which he’d been transported to our rescue centre. I lifted the raven out to inspect him: he was huge, with a comically large head that looked out of proportion to the rest of his body and an enormous, slightly downward-curving beak. His feathers were a dull black, but his squawks of protest revealed a bright-red throat. Most striking of all were his intelligent black eyes.”

Paragraph 5: “We finally realised he was a hopeless case when he stole a sandwich, taking it off into a field. A wild raven landed close to him and approached. Odin gave a petrified croak, scampering for the safety of the barn, and the intruder flew off with his prize. ‘We’ll never get rid of him,’ I thought.”

Paragraph 11: “Days later, by chance, another local farmer came to help us. Julie and I had already made a brave start on rebuilding the sheds, mournfully avoiding the remains of the cage. When I mentioned wistfully it had housed our raven, the farmer told me about a black bird that had been following his tractor the previous day. ‘Had a massive beak,’ he said. ‘Didn’t stop talking. Amazing.’”

Paragraph 13: “We arrived at the field as dusk was falling. There was no sign of Odin, but plenty of trees still left here in which he might be resting. I walked over to them, shining my torch upwards. Weak cheeping revealed the smallest shadow of a bedraggled Odin perched precariously at the top of the tallest tree and shivering violently. Seriously shaken by his experience, he wasn’t in a trusting mood. At the risk of appearing a complete idiot, I called up in a hopefully endearing voice, ‘Odin, come to Daddy.’ The bird’s response was immediate. With a croak of relief he dropped from the tree like a bundle of black rags, landing at my feet. Normally he hated being picked up, but on this occasion our indestructible raven was more than willing to be scooped into my arms and taken home.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraphs 1, 5, 11 and 13

Explain using your own words how Rex’s feelings about the bird change over time. Give three details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

**[3]
R2**

HOW TO ANSWER

Build an emotional journey. Select three DIFFERENT feelings. Match one precise detail to each feeling. One supported feeling–evidence pair earns one mark.

MODEL ANSWER

Initially, Rex is amused by Odin’s “comically large head”. Later, he becomes frustrated because Odin is “a nuisance”. After the storm, Rex feels sad and worried as he “mournfully” avoids the remains of the cage.

Marks: three different, supported feeling–evidence pairs = 3

COMMON TRAP

“Frightened, scared and terrified” belong to one emotional family. Also avoid retelling the story without naming feelings.

SIR RUFUS TIP

Beginning → change → ending. Every feeling needs its own matching evidence.

Precision feelings bank

Mild/controlled	Clear emotion	Stronger emotion
uneasy	anxious	terrified
displeased	annoyed	furious
surprised	astonished	stunned
pleased	delighted	ecstatic
concerned	worried	distressed

SIR RUFUS TIP

Choose the correct intensity. Nervous does not automatically mean terrified.

YOUR TURN — Mixed Q1 Practice

INSTRUCTIONS

Read each official extract carefully. Underline the command words, paragraph/line reference and required number of details. Answer before checking the key on the next page.

Practice Extract A

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“The young bird seemed too big for the box in which he’d been transported to our rescue centre. I lifted the raven out to inspect him: he was huge, with a comically large head that looked out of proportion to the rest of his body and an enormous, slightly downward-curving beak.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 1, lines 1–4

In paragraph 1, what does Rex find amusing about the young bird’s appearance when Rex first sees him?

[1]
R1

Practice Extract B

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“His feathers were a dull black, but his squawks of protest revealed a bright-red throat.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 1, line 4

Using your own words, explain what Rex means by the bird’s “squawks of protest”.

[2]
R1

Practice Extract C

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“We finally realised he was a hopeless case when he stole a sandwich, taking it off into a field. A wild raven landed close to him and approached. Odin gave a petrified croak, scampering for the safety of the barn, and the intruder flew off with his prize.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 5, lines 21–23

Explain why Odin gives a “petrified croak”.

[1]
R2

Practice Extract D

READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“My plan, as always, was to get the bird back into the wild, but this one would be tricky. Birds not only have to learn to find their own food, they also must learn to spot predators – difficult when a bird’s been in captivity from an early age with no parents to teach by example. It’s important when rearing wild birds that they’re kept as wild as possible, not treated like pets, so they have a chance of survival once released. This raven was called Odin and had no fear of people.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, paragraph 3, lines 11–15

From paragraph 3, give two features of the bird’s upbringing that will make it difficult to return this bird to the wild.

[2]
R1

ANSWER KEY AND FINAL CHECK

Mixed-practice answers

MODEL ANSWER

- A. Rex is amused by the bird’s very large head and enormous beak, which appear out of proportion to its body. [1]
- B. The bird makes loud, harsh cries because it is angry, unhappy or resisting being handled. [2]
- C. Odin is terrified of the unfamiliar wild raven and runs for safety. [1]
- D. He has not learned to find his own food, and he had no parents to teach him how to recognise predators. [2]

Final Q1 checklist

- I identified the exact command word.
- I stayed inside the stated paragraph or line range.
- I gave the required number of separate details.
- I replaced every tested meaning when own words were required.
- I explained the cause in a “why” question.
- I inferred thoughts or feelings from textual clues.
- I matched every feeling with relevant evidence.
- I used short, precise quotations rather than copying long sections.
- I checked that my answer directly addresses the focus.



SIR RUFUS' FINAL ADVICE

Read the instruction first. In R1, locate and select. In R2, infer and prove. Write enough to earn the marks—then stop.